

privilege, gods and evangelists. Panas, relatively better off, are mostly Christians, the beneficiaries of conversion, which offers some kind of economic security and educational opportunities. The tribal grievance is that the Panas get the best of both worlds as conversions are not officially recorded but steeped in secrecy, for, legally, a convert ceases to be a Scheduled Caste. In the last 40 years, there have been only two officially recorded conversions in Kandhamal. And there are around 1,400 churches of various denominations in the district. Swami Lakshmanananda, whose murder ignited the tribal rage against the Church, was the Hindu evangelist, so to speak.

Why did the Patnaik administration allow the communal passion to turn violent in the wake the Swami's murder? The chief minister refuses to own up the blame. "We didn't have adequate number of forces to deal with the volatile situation. I spoke to the home minister asking for more forces but they didn't arrive in time." He shows you a copy of the letter he had written to Shivraj Patil on October 4: "... The additional forces that we asked for on 23.08.2008 started arriving in Kandhamal district only from 27.08.2006. Thus the district was left to fend for itself with the available forces from 23.08.2008 to 27.08.2008 when the violence following the killing of the Swamiji was at its peak.... The impression that the Government of Orissa has made unreasonable demands for Central forces is, therefore, not correct. Nor is it correct to argue that the Union Government has fully met the requirements of the state Government...It is, therefore, not the time to point fingers at the efforts of the state Government to bring a very difficult situation under control."

He tells you that Kandhamal is under control. "As chief minister, it is my duty to maintain peace and harmony." He doesn't think that he has failed. "In the eight-and-a-half years I have been chief minister, there have been only two communal incidents—the one in December last year and the current flare up, and both in Kandhamal." He is planning a package for the area. "In nine months, for instance, hostels were built to house

one lakh tribal girls." He has not abandoned hope—or idealism. "It only makes me firmer in my belief that matters will improve." Such optimism, though, does not make him a happy politician. Kandhamal is more than a political test. "It is the most regrettable thing that has happened in the 11 years of my public life. I'm resolved to solve it."

If you listen to his opponents, there will be no resolution as long as he is in power. "I hold this Government entirely responsible for whatever hap-

HINDU FURY: Followers of Swami Lakshmanananda protest his killing



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

FOR THE RECORD

"That Orissa has made unreasonable demands for central forces is not correct."

"I spoke to the Home Minister asking for more security forces but they did not arrive in time."

pened in Kandhamal. There is no political leadership in the state," says former chief minister and Congress leader J.B. Patnaik. "How can a person who doesn't know the language of his people run a state. He has no idea of Orissa," says the old warhorse. He doesn't stop there. "He is the most corrupt man. He spent almost a crore for every constituency in the last election. I know they are going to spend two crore this time. Where does the money come from? He didn't inherit that much money from his father."

This Patnaik is bitter, for he knows that his young rival is one of the most politically secure—and popular—chief ministers of the country. And 'corrupt' is one adjective that doesn't go with him at all. "He is one politician in the state who has no vested interest," says Rabi Das, a seasoned observer of the state's political evolution. For Bijoy Mohapatra, once Biju Patnaik's favourite and later the son's victim and